Oxford AI Assessment Playbook

A practical implementation guide for faculty and module leads

STATUS AND SCOPE

This is practical guidance developed at Saïd Business School for local academic discussion. It is not University policy and has not been formally endorsed. It supports, and does not replace, the University policy on AI use in summative assessment, Examination Regulations, local approval processes, accessibility requirements and programme guidance.

Use it to move from the intended learning to a clear AI-use category, evidence of student learning and adaptable assessment wording. It covers common assessment types rather than prescribing one University-wide design.

ASSESSMENT-DESIGN PRINCIPLE

Make student learning and judgement visible.

The central question is not simply “Did AI write this?” but whether the assessment provides credible evidence that the student can reach a reasoned conclusion and explain, defend and apply it. Keeping an existing assessment unchanged is a legitimate outcome when it already does this.

The five-step workflow

1 Clarify the purpose

State the knowledge, reasoning, judgement, performance or professional capability the assessment should evidence.

2 Choose the AI-use category

Decide whether AI use is not authorised, selective use authorised or integral use required, and describe the tasks any selective use covers. These names follow the illustrative categories in the CTL briefing note; use any categories your department or programme has formally adopted.

3 Check the evidence

Ask whether, under that category, the work will still give sufficient evidence of the intended learning. Keeping the assessment as it is can be the right answer. The optional VIVA reference (valid, inclusive, visible, accountable) is one way to structure the check.

4 Write the instructions and declaration

Issue clear written guidance in advance for each summative assessment. Specify permitted, required and excluded uses and the declaration expected, using any format your department prescribes.

5 Mark, review and improve

Apply the approved marking criteria, review the assessment after use and update the design through the usual approval route when evidence, student experience or technology changes.

AI-use categories

Categories are a shared language, not an assessment design. Their value depends on alignment with the intended learning, disciplinary context, equitable access, staff capacity, marking and workable implementation. The University policy does not prescribe named categories; formally adopted local categories take precedence.

Not authorised

Closed exam; unaided calculation; live performance.

USE IT WHEN

Independent performance is itself the capability being assessed.

WHAT STUDENTS NEED

A clear statement, and which assistive technology or reasonable adjustments are covered.

Selective use authorised

Specific listed tasks

Proofreading; finding sources; checking code.

USE IT WHEN

Specific support can assist without replacing the intended learning.

WHAT STUDENTS NEED

An explicit list of permitted and excluded tasks, and the declaration format.

Selective use authorised

Wider use within stated limits

Take-home analysis with source checking.

USE IT WHEN

AI may support broad parts of the process, but the student remains responsible for judgement and evidence.

WHAT STUDENTS NEED

The limits, what must be verified and the declaration format.

Integral use required

Audit, compare or improve AI output.

USE IT WHEN

Using and evaluating AI is part of the learning outcome.

WHAT STUDENTS NEED

The required tool, equal baseline access, safeguards and the declaration format.

Implementation safeguards

Process evidence is evidence, not proof of authorship. Oral follow-up is not a universal gold standard.

Where AI could materially obscure the capability being assessed, draw on more than one proportionate source of evidence, such as the submitted work together with staged drafts, explanation or dialogue. No single component proves authorship.

Any oral or additional component that affects marks should be specified in advance, consistently applied, accessible, proportionate and locally approved. Do not question only the students suspected of AI use.

Assessment types

Timed exams and in-class tests

1. Define whether the task tests recall, method, reasoning, interpretation or application.
2. Use approved controlled conditions and explain why AI is not authorised, if that is the decision.
3. Require workings, justification or application rather than final answers alone.
4. Check accessibility, reasonable adjustments, time pressure and platform reliability.
5. Rotate or refresh questions for assessment quality, not because novelty makes them inaccessible to AI.

> **ADAPTABLE WORDING: COMPLETE THE BRACKETS**
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> AI use is not authorised in this assessment because independent performance under controlled conditions is part of the capability being assessed. [State any authorised assistive technology or reasonable-adjustment arrangements.]

Take-home essays

1. State the argument, synthesis or disciplinary judgement the essay should evidence.
2. Choose the AI-use category before deciding whether drafts, plans or reflections are needed.
3. Use specific course material, comparison, application or a justified critical position.
4. Ask for proportionate process evidence only when it contributes to learning or assessment validity.
5. Align criteria with reasoning, evidence and judgement rather than presentation alone.

> **ADAPTABLE WORDING: COMPLETE THE BRACKETS**
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> AI may be used only for [permitted tasks]. It must not be used to [excluded tasks]. Your final argument, interpretation and use of evidence must be your own. Include the prescribed declaration before the references.

Literature reviews

1. Decide whether literature discovery, screening, synthesis or writing is being assessed.
2. Require a transparent search strategy appropriate to the discipline.
3. Ask students to verify every AI-suggested source against the original record.
4. Use annotated source notes or inclusion and exclusion reasoning where these evidence the learning outcome.
5. Mark synthesis, evaluation and judgement, not the number of sources found.

> **ADAPTABLE WORDING: COMPLETE THE BRACKETS**
>
> Where AI is used for literature discovery or organisation, verify each source against the original publication and declare the tool, purpose and verification process. AI-generated citations must not be treated as verified sources.

Case studies and policy memos

1. Clarify whether the task tests diagnosis, recommendation, trade-offs, evidence use or communication to an audience.
2. Use supplied data and a specific decision context rather than relying on novelty or secrecy.
3. Require a prioritised recommendation and explicit reasoning.
4. Make assumptions, limitations and trade-offs visible.
5. Use an oral or written defence only where proportionate and consistently designed.

> **ADAPTABLE WORDING: COMPLETE THE BRACKETS**
>
> Your recommendation must be justified using the supplied evidence and explicit trade-offs. AI may be used for [tasks], but you remain responsible for the analysis, source verification and final recommendation.

Presentations and posters

1. Decide whether the assessment tests content, communication, visual design, oral response or all four.
2. State whether AI may support research, scripting, slide design or rehearsal.
3. Use individual questioning or explanation where it is part of the intended learning.
4. Provide consistent criteria and reasonable adjustments for any live component.
5. For groups, include a contribution statement and an individual evidence component where appropriate.

ADAPTABLE WORDING: COMPLETE THE BRACKETS

AI may be used for [preparation tasks]. It may not be used during the live assessed component unless explicitly stated. Be prepared to explain the evidence, choices and recommendations in your presentation.

Group projects

1. Separate the team product from the individual learning that needs to be evidenced.
2. Use milestone decisions, role records or contribution statements proportionately.
3. Specify whether the AI-use instructions apply to the team, each member or both.
4. Avoid process logging that creates excessive surveillance or workload.
5. Use peer or individual evidence with transparent criteria.

ADAPTABLE WORDING: COMPLETE THE BRACKETS

Each team member must submit a short contribution and AI-use statement identifying their role, any substantive AI assistance and how outputs were checked. The team remains jointly responsible for the final submission.

Problem sets and quantitative work

1. Identify whether the learning lies in method selection, calculation, interpretation or modelling judgement.
2. Require workings and conceptual explanation where they provide relevant evidence.
3. Decide whether AI may check, generate or explain code and calculations.
4. Use parameter variation for breadth and feedback, not as a guarantee against AI use.
5. Mark method, assumptions, error checking and interpretation.

ADAPTABLE WORDING: COMPLETE THE BRACKETS

AI may be used for [checking / formatting / debugging] but not to generate the submitted solution. Show your workings and explain why the selected method is appropriate. Declare any substantive AI assistance.

Coding and data analysis

1. Decide whether syntax, architecture, debugging, analysis, interpretation or professional use of AI is being assessed.
2. Require explanation of key design and analytical choices.
3. Use version history, notebooks or demonstrations where they support the learning outcome.
4. Require comments or a declaration for substantive AI-generated code.
5. Mark understanding, testing, reproducibility, limitations and interpretation.

ADAPTABLE WORDING: COMPLETE THE BRACKETS

AI coding tools may be used for [permitted tasks]. You must understand, test and be able to explain all submitted code. Identify substantive AI-generated or AI-modified code and describe how it was verified.

Research proposals and dissertations

1. Define permitted AI use by stage: question development, literature work, methods, analysis, drafting and editing.
2. Use supervision and milestones as developmental evidence, not forensic proof.
3. Apply both the assessment instructions and the University research policy where relevant.
4. Address data protection, confidentiality, ethics, intellectual property, funder and publisher rules.
5. Require a declaration in the location and form prescribed locally.

> **ADAPTABLE WORDING: COMPLETE THE BRACKETS**
>
> AI use is governed by the written assessment instructions, the University research policy where applicable and local departmental requirements. Declare substantive use, verify outputs and remain responsible for the research design, evidence, analysis and final text.

AI-integral critique or simulation

1. Make the AI-related capability an explicit learning outcome.
2. Provide equal baseline access to the required tool or a suitable alternative.
3. Assess prompting only where it is pedagogically relevant; prioritise evaluation and judgement.
4. Require verification against disciplinary sources and identification of limitations.
5. Plan for tool failure, model variation and accessibility.

> **ADAPTABLE WORDING: COMPLETE THE BRACKETS**
>
> Use of [tool or capability] is required for this assessment. Your marks will be based on how well you evaluate, verify, improve and take responsibility for the output, not on the fluency of the AI-generated content alone.

Minimum quality check

Seven statements that should be true before the assessment is issued.

- The intended learning and the reason for the AI-use category are explicit.
- Students receive written guidance before the assessment and know what to declare.
- Permitted tools are equitably available or an appropriate alternative is provided.
- The design is accessible, proportionate and manageable for students, markers and administrators.
- Approved marking criteria reward the intended knowledge, reasoning, judgement or performance.
- No claim is made that a format, process record or oral component proves authorship or is AI-proof.
- The design has the necessary local approval and fits Examination Regulations and programme requirements.

Official sources

AI use in summative assessment (University policy)	www.ox.ac.uk/about/how-we-are-run/policies-and-statements/policy-hub/ai-use-in-summative-assessment
Generative AI at Oxford	www.ox.ac.uk/gen-ai
Centre for Teaching and Learning: AI in teaching and learning	www.ox.ac.uk/about/how-we-are-run/education/centre-for-teaching-and-learning/ai-in-teaching-and-learning
CTL briefing note on developing categories for AI use in summative assessment	OxIntranet (Oxford sign-in)